

As I Was Saying **BOB INGRAM** SPORTS EDITOR

Some Who Won't Be Here

A NICE LITTLE PARLOR game right now is guessing the lineup of the Sun Kings for the coming season. This is not an easy game to play because information on all the players the California Angels will have at their minor league camp at Holtville, Calif., is not available.

It would be easier to find out who won't be here or who isn't likely to be around.

By a process of elimination we can say most likely that Aurelio (Leo) Rodriguez, who started the season at third base for the Kings in 1967 and played there until the big league All-Star break late in June, will not return. He's set as the third baseman of the California Angels or nearly set for that post. The 20-year-old native of Mexico made a spectacular rise in baseball.

Another player who most likely won't return is Don Wilkinson, outfielder. He was drafted by the New York Mets, which you might think would definitely preclude him returning to El Paso. But the Mets, who paid \$25,000 for him in the draft, have the privilege of selling him back for \$10,000 to the Kings' parent club if they don't want him. It's likely the Mets will keep him. Gil Hodges, the new manager of the Mets, talked to Andy Cohen at the recent NCAA convention in New York City like he planned to give Wilkinson a good shot at an outfielder's job with the big club.

Spencer Due Promotion

ANOTHER PLAYER who isn't likely to return is Jim Spencer, young first baseman. After two fine seasons with the Kings, he's due to go up to the Angels' AAA club, the Seattle team in the Pacific Coast league.

Spencer, as every big league scout who saw him will attest, had as good qualifications for a big league future as anyone on the club.

He may not quite be ready for the majors but he isn't far off. A year in the Pacific Coast League might get him ready.

It's doubtful if Tom Egan, the big catcher, will return. He should get a good chance at Seattle.

Egan, even though he led the Kings in hitting last season, was the hard luck man of the team. When he was called up for two weeks of military service late in the season, he had reached the coveted .300 mark. The club had not planned to call him back but did so when the Kings stayed close in the T.L. race. Egan's bat had cooled off when he returned and in the final two weeks of the season, he slumped to .291.

It's very doubtful if Paul Schaal, who came directly from the Angels to El Paso and played the final weeks here, will return. He looked too good for the Angels to keep in AA ball.

Nobody Knows Who'll Be Back

THERE'S LESS certainty about some of the other 1967 Sun Kings not returning. In fact, a good many of them most certainly will be back. They could include Gordon Avery, Jim Vopicka, Vic LaRose, Carlos Trevino, Ethan Blackaby and a number of hurlers including Jim Holbrook, Dan Keller, Andy Messersmith, Pat Rogan and others.

It would not be surprising to see Felipe Leal get another chance in the Texas League. Anyone who pitches a shutout and a no-hit, no-run game in the league should, it appears, be good enough to stay.

But Leal, who was either very good or very bad, was shipped to San Jose in the California League. The only two victories he turned in while a Sun King were his no-hitter, thrown against Albuquerque, and his shutout.

Fire-balling Tom Murphy, sent here in the last couple of months in the 1967 season is in town getting ready to join the Angels in their camp at Palm Springs. He'll try to make the big club. If he doesn't, it'll either be Seattle or El Paso for him.

Chuck Tanner will be in El Paso about the middle of March on his way to spring training. Chances are he won't know much more then on the composition of the 1968 Kings than the club knows now.